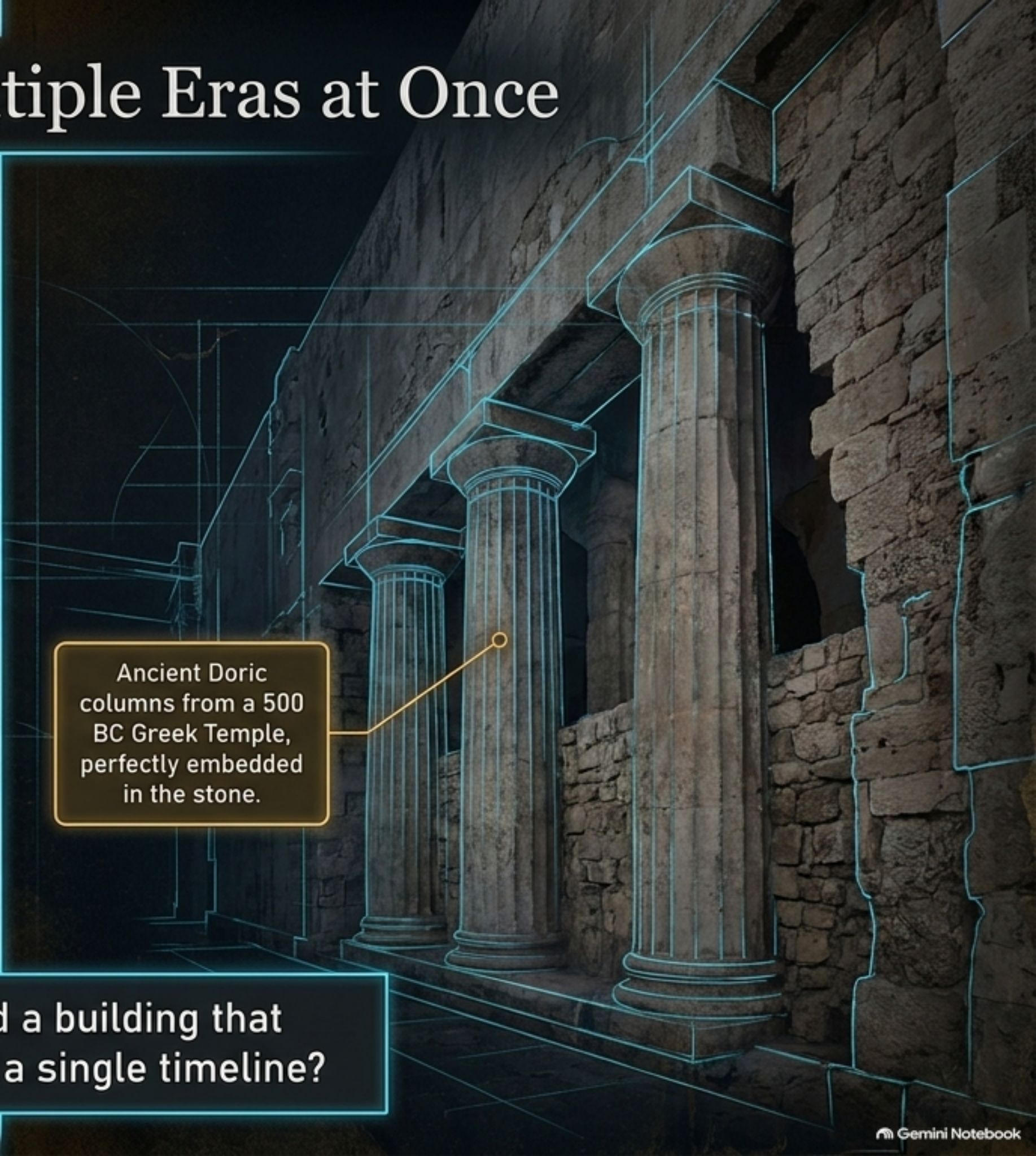


A Building in Multiple Eras at Once



A masterwork of
18th-century
Sicilian Baroque by
Andrea Palma.

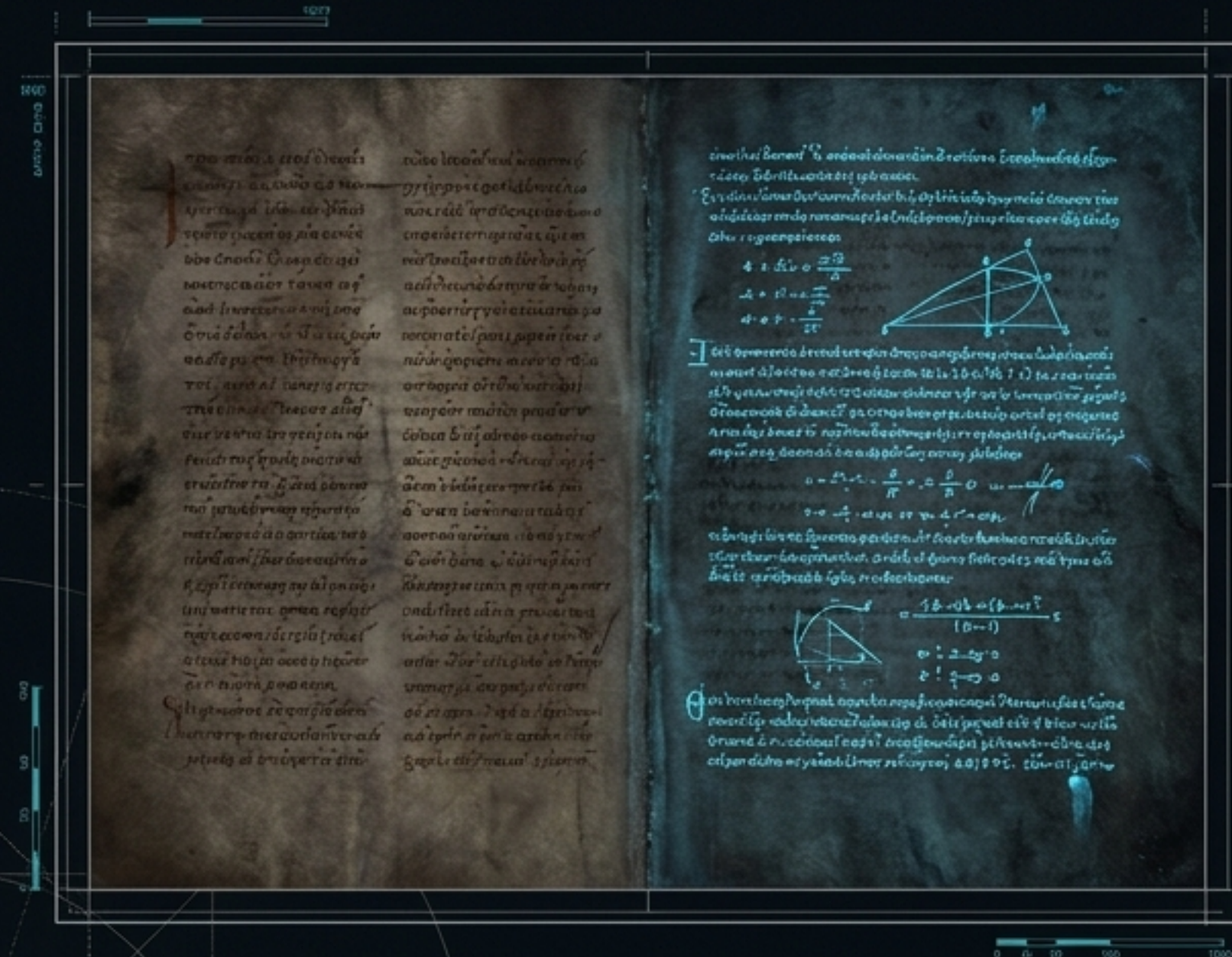


Ancient Doric
columns from a 500
BC Greek Temple,
perfectly embedded
in the stone.

How do we read a building that
refuses to inhabit a single timeline?

Borrowing a Lens from Paleography: The Palimpsest

In antiquity, parchment (vellum) was highly valuable. To reuse it, original ink was scraped away, but traces survived. The Greek word *palimpsestos* literally means "scraped clean again." Buildings, too, can be scraped and rewritten, physically expressing the progression of time and shifting cultural paradigms.



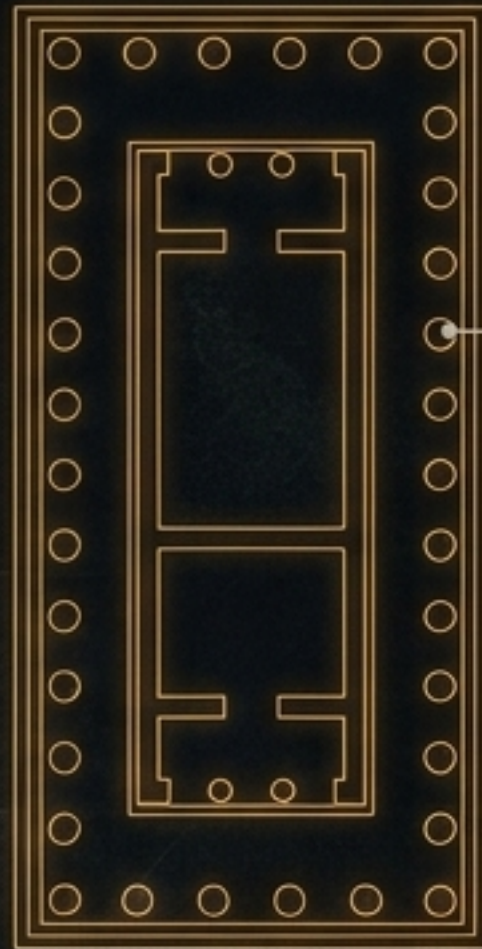
10th-century mathematics accidentally preserved under 13th-century liturgy.



500 BC Doric columns intentionally preserved within a 7th-century medieval wall.

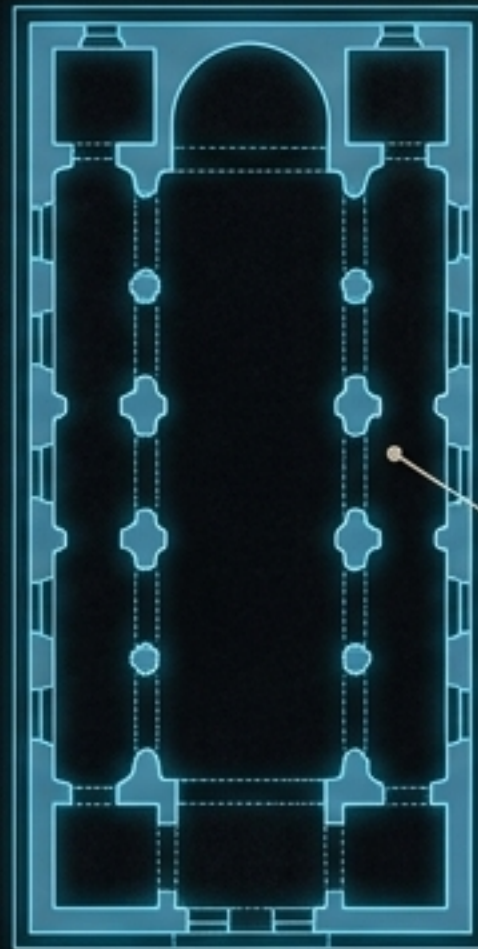
Anatomy of an Architectural Palimpsest: Spatial Entanglement

1. 500 BC (The Greek Athenaion)



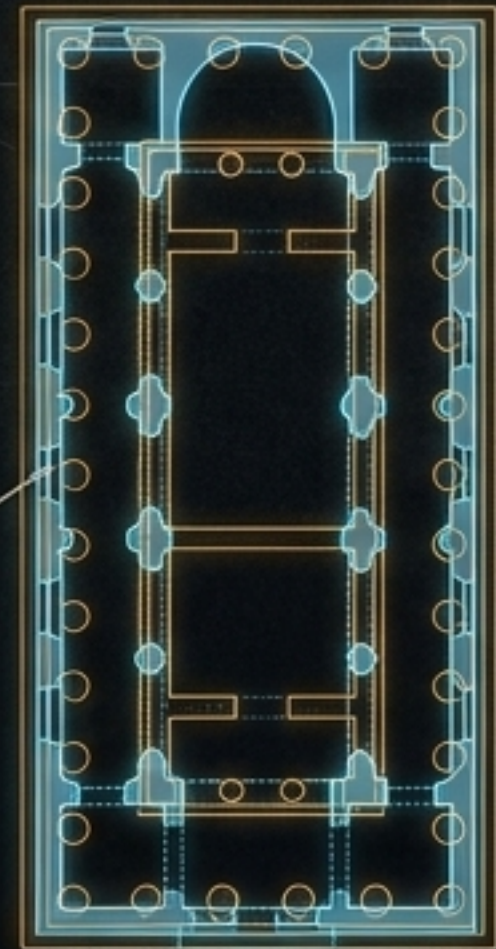
An outward-facing, open-air peripteral temple built by King Gelon.

2. 7th Century (The Byzantine Church)



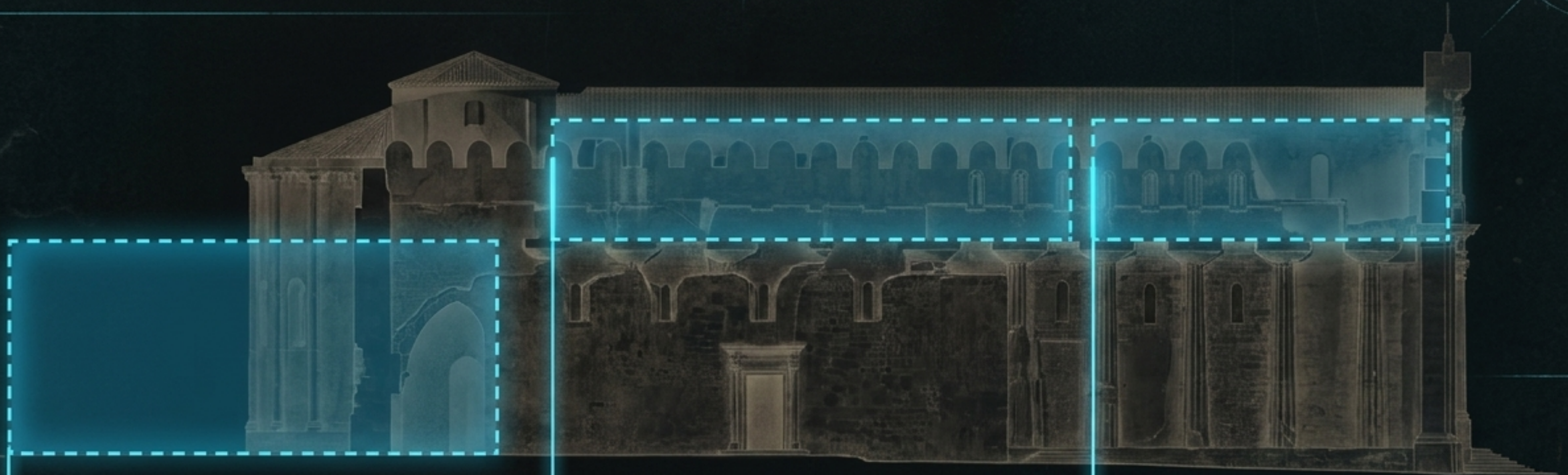
Bishop Zosimo orders a spatial inversion. The exterior columns are walled up; the inner cella is punctured with arches to create a Christian nave.

3. The Entanglement



Unlike a manuscript where flat layers sit passively on a surface, an architectural palimpsest is a three-dimensional entanglement. The new relies entirely on the structural integrity of the old.

The Politics of Erasure



The Missing Arab Layer (9th–11th C)
The Missing Arab Layer (9th–11th C)

The Aghlabids and Fatimids ruled Syracuse, highly likely utilizing the site as a mosque.

The Void: Zero physical traces remain, suggesting subsequent conquerors violently erased the Islamic layer to assert dominance.

The Norman Additions (11th–12th C)
The Norman Additions (11th–12th C)

The Normans raised the walls and added battlements. They selectively preserved the Greek layer while wiping the Arab memory clean, dictating what history survived.

Modern “Purification” (1911)
Modern “Purification” (1911)

Archeologist Paolo Orsi deliberately stripped away post-Baroque additions. The Void: Erasure driven by modern academic ideals of finding a ‘pure’ historical state at the cost of the natural physical palimpsest.

The Rules of the Palimpsest: Paper vs. Stone

	 PAPER (Paleography)	 STONE (Architecture)
Driving Motive	Economic & Utility. Parchment is an expensive commodity; reuse is a cheap necessity.	Cultural & Ideological. The site holds deeply rooted historical continuity, ritual power, or political legitimation.
Intent Toward the Past	Total Erasure. The underlying layer is actively destroyed; its survival is purely accidental.	Intentional Juxtaposition. The past layer is actively retained and framed to confer ancient authority upon the present.
Structural Interaction	Independent. The stacked ink layers exist passively and ignore one another.	Interdependent. The layers structurally hold each other up; removing the old physically destroys the new.

The Immaterial Threads: The Glue of Cultural Memory

If a building is a clashing hybrid of Greek, Byzantine, Norman, and Spanish Baroque parts, why does it feel like a unified entity?

Because immaterial legends stitch the timeline together.

The Victory of Gelon (480 BC)

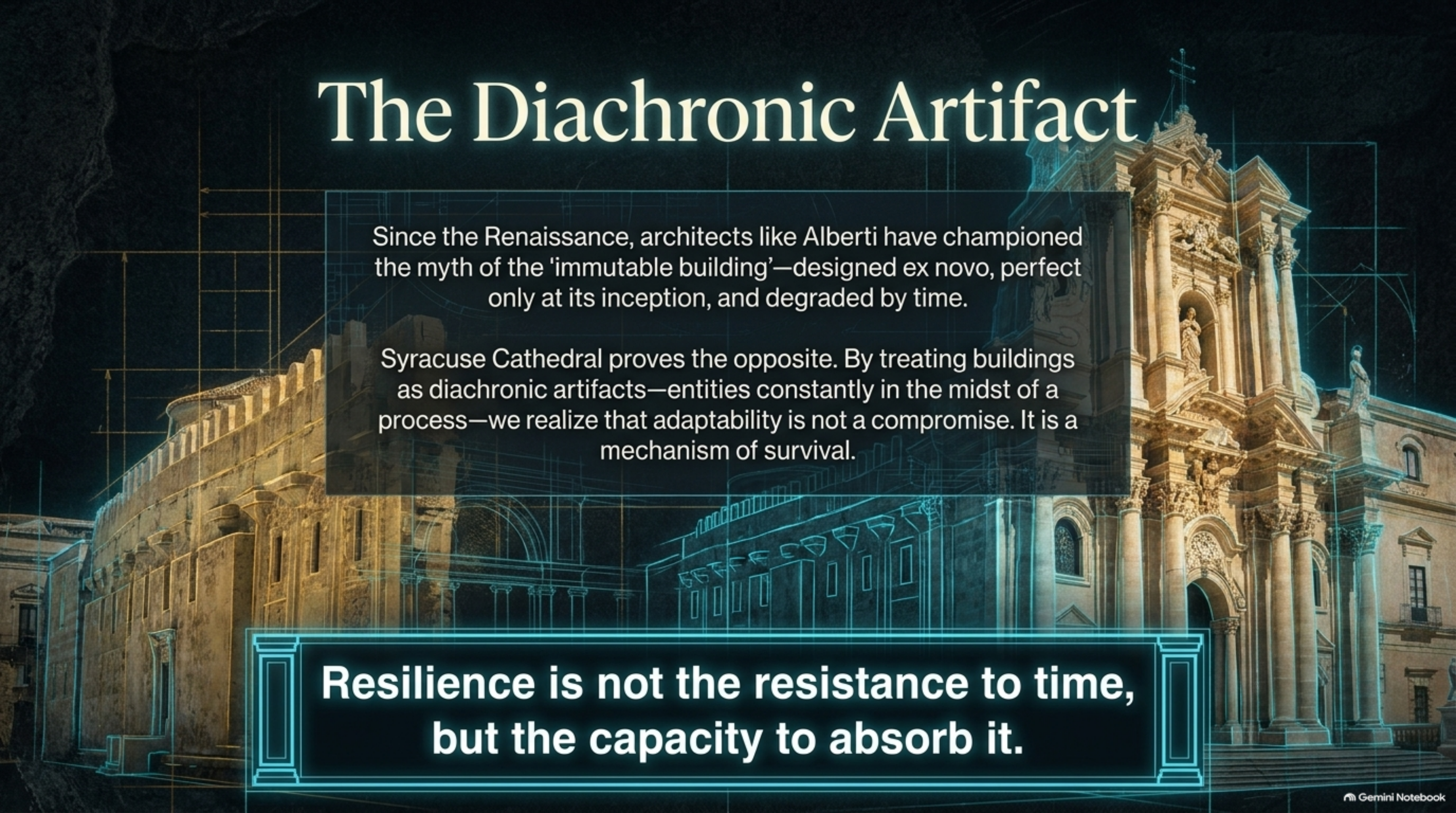
The memory of the Battle of Himera embeds deep civic pride into the original stones.

The Apostolic Foundation (~40 AD)

A Byzantine legend linking the site to St. Peter's envoy, Marcian. An inscription on the nave wall still declares it the "First daughter of St. Peter."

Insight: These immaterial narratives retroactively synthesize the disparate physical eras into a single, continuous identity.

The Diachronic Artifact

The background of the slide features a composite image. On the right, the Syracuse Cathedral is shown, a grand Baroque structure with multiple tiers of columns and a tall bell tower. On the left, the Theatre of Greek Ruins is visible, a large ancient stone structure. Overlaid on these images are faint, glowing blue and yellow architectural lines, including grids and perspective drawings of buildings, which create a sense of historical layering and architectural analysis.

Since the Renaissance, architects like Alberti have championed the myth of the 'immutable building'—designed ex novo, perfect only at its inception, and degraded by time.

Syracuse Cathedral proves the opposite. By treating buildings as diachronic artifacts—entities constantly in the midst of a process—we realize that adaptability is not a compromise. It is a mechanism of survival.

**Resilience is not the resistance to time,
but the capacity to absorb it.**